Chapter 6
From Ideas to Startups



The Big Questions

1. *How does entrepreneurship impact society and the economy?*
2. *What are some functional areas of a business?*
3. *How to develop a business plan?*

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Imagine your school is hosting an annual festival, and you participate in the 'Young Entrepreneurs Challenge', where you have to develop a product or service for parents and children visiting your stall. You come up with an idea for a lemonade *(nimbu pani)* and set up a stall with your classmates. At the end of the day, you prepare and submit a detailed report on the expenses incurred and the **profit** made to your class teacher.

What do you think is required to run the stall? You will have to decide how much to spend on lemons and sugar, where to procure glasses, how much to charge for each glass, and so on. Also, you will have to assess how many people liked the drink and if you made a profit or loss. This simple activity captures the essence of running a business—planning, organising, and learning by doing. This is **entrepreneurship**, a process through which individuals, or a group of individuals, convert a potential idea into a business venture.

Every great business starts with an idea, a need, or a desire to innovate



Fig. 6.1. Elements of entrepreneurship

Profit: Money that is earned in trade or business after paying the costs of producing and selling goods and services.

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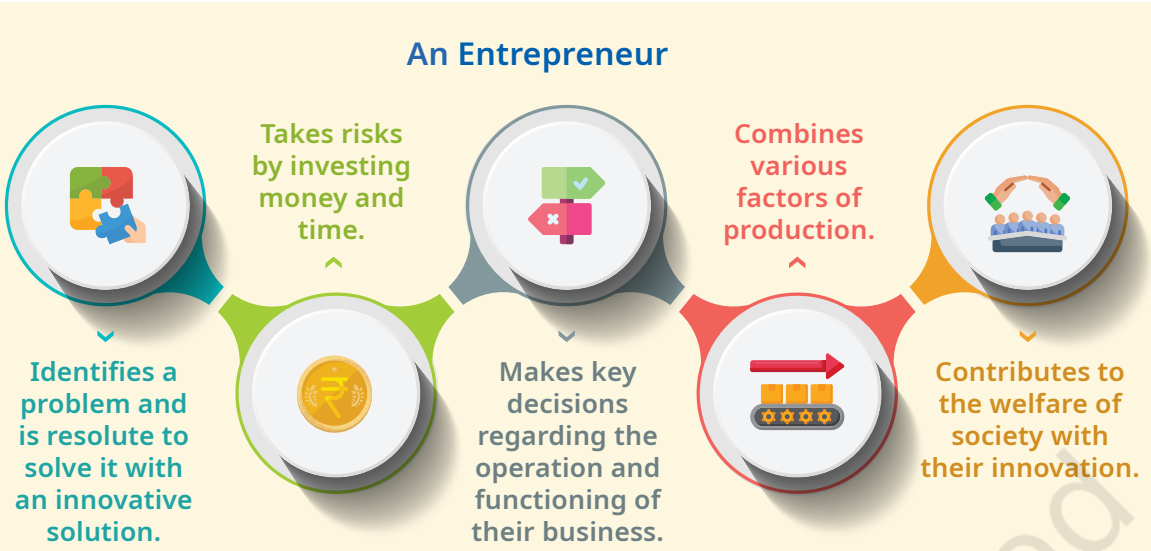


Fig. 6.2. Tasks performed by an entrepreneur

and meet the needs of society. Entrepreneurs are curious individuals who see opportunities where others see challenges and turn that spark into action. Whether it is leading a business that manufactures drones for traffic surveillance or creating eco-friendly jute bags that can replace plastic, an entrepreneur works hard, and is driven by passion and a commitment to creating value for society. Let us understand this through a story.

From a Dead Mouse to Riches

One day, a rich merchant told his king, "Even a dead mouse can be the start of a fortune, if someone works hard and uses their brain." A poor young man overheard this and decided to test it. He picked up a dead mouse and sold it to a shopkeeper for two coins since his cat was hungry. With those coins, the young man bought fruits and water, which he sold to a tired flower picker in exchange for flowers. He then sold the flowers in the city.



Fig. 6.3.

Step by step, he grew his small earnings by clearing fallen branches after a storm and selling them as firewood, trading grass with horse dealers, opening a refreshment shop to later even striking business with foreign merchants.

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With intelligence, dedication, and hard work the man became very wealthy. But he did not forget how it all started—with the merchant's words. Out of gratitude, he gave the merchant half his fortune. Also, the man used his wealth not just for himself, but to help communities in the city as well.


Fig. 6.4.

The story above is from the famous *Jataka Tales*. What can you take away from the tale? Is it about spotting opportunities or working smart? What kind of traits do you think entrepreneurs need to have? Discuss with your classmates.

Let us learn about stories of a few entrepreneurial minds who turned their ideas into reality.

From Rooftop to Revolution

In 1959, seven ordinary homemakers from a Mumbai **chawl** gathered on a rooftop with borrowed equipment, a recipe, and ₹80. Their goal was modest—earn some extra income by making and selling *papads.* They had no business degrees, no investors, and no master plan; instead, what they had was grit and unity. There were no factories at first; each woman took raw dough home every morning, rolled *papads* through the day between household tasks, and returned the finished pieces by evening with the condition that 'the quality had to be consistent'. They decided to start a cooperative society where every member who joined would be an equal owner, and profits would be shared equally regardless of seniority.

Chawl: A traditional, multi-storey residential tenement building, typically consisting of dense, single-room units.

In 1962, they registered the venture as Shri Mahila Griha Udyog Lijjat Papad, a cooperative society, where 'lijjat' means tasty in Gujarati. Afterwards, many branches opened across India and garnered thousands of members. In the 1980s and 90s, Lijjat expanded into other products like flour, masalas, and soaps, and exports began too, crossing a turnover of ₹100 crore. By 2023, the cooperative had over 45,000 women members, 83 branches, and an annual turnover of ₹1,600 crore.

The women begin work early in the morning, facilitated by pick-up and drop-off bus services. Lijjat also provides scholarships to

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Fig. 6.5.

the school-going children of the members to encourage them to pursue further education. The organisation has helped thousands of women become financially independent, empowered communities, and built a large-scale business while being completely self-reliant.

THINK ABOUT IT



- What problem was Lijjat solving beyond just selling *papads*?
- What challenges do you think the founders could have faced at the start? How might they have overcome them?
- Can you think of a similar cooperative idea you could start in your community?

The Man who Transformed the Hospitality Industry

Born in Punjab in 1898, Mohan Singh Oberoi faced hardships early in life when his father passed away while he was still an infant. After somehow completing his education, he moved to Shimla and took a job as a hotel desk clerk, earning just ₹50 a month.

Rather than limiting himself to his assigned duties, Mohan learned every aspect of hotel operations, from guest service to billing and administration. His dedication, curiosity, and willingness to take initiative set him apart.

In 1934, he took a bold step by **mortgaging** his wife's jewellery and investing all his savings to buy a small hotel. Despite the risks, he believed in his vision. Through hard work and determination, he

Mortgage: A mortgage is a special type of loan used to buy a house or land with some collateral.

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transformed struggling hotels into successful businesses, and went on to build one of India's largest hotel chains. He later established luxury hotels, founded a hotel management school, and expanded his business across the world. In 2001, the Government of India accorded him the Padma Bhushan. He passed away in 2002; by then, the Oberoi Group, named after him, had become one of the world's most respected hotel brands.

His journey shows how entrepreneurship is not only about having a good idea. It involves planning, teamwork, decision making, and the effective management of different areas of the business. For example:

- He **hired and trained skilled** staff to provide excellent hospitality services, and constantly worked to improve hotel facilities and guest experiences.
- He carefully **managed the business's finances** to support growth and expansion.
- His hotels were **renovated and operated efficiently** to maintain high standards.
- The company **built a trusted brand** known for luxury and quality service.
- **Customer satisfaction** remained the top priority in all hotel operations.



These are some of the functions that entrepreneurs and their teams perform. There are departments or groups within a company that focus on such distinct tasks and shared skills, also known as functional areas. Let us understand them in detail and learn how a business plan is prepared.

Business Plan—A Road Map for the Business

Let us assume that you and your friends decide to open a bakery together that offers snacks and desserts. How would you go about it? You have to consider many crucial questions, identify challenges, and plan at every stage before starting the bakery to turn this simple idea into a successful business venture. This is when a business plan is developed. It is a written document, a blueprint explaining the goals of the business and the steps to achieve them. It guides the entrepreneur from the initial idea stage to successfully starting and running the business. It also serves as a guide and roadmap for

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decision making, helping them stay organised, set priorities, and work systematically to grow the business.

Exploring aspects such as those listed below could be especially helpful while creating a business plan.



Fig. 6.6. Key considerations in making a Business Plan

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1. **Needs and idea:** To understand what people want, you would have to understand customer needs.
    - Do customers prefer fresh bread, cakes, pastries, or healthier options like whole wheat products?
    - Will the bakery provide fresh, affordable, or unique baked goods that were not available in the area before?
2. **Potential customers:** Knowing your customers helps you decide what kind of products to offer. To identify the target consumers, one may think about:
    - Decide whether to specialise in offering cakes, cupcakes for children, or savoury snacks for young adults, or everyday breads and confectionery items for families.
3. **Money and costs:** Your business needs a robust financial start, which begins with planning finances and estimating the initial investment required. This includes the cost of equipment, such as an oven, rent for the premise, staff salaries, ingredients, such as flour and nuts, and packaging.
    - How should funds be arranged? (through savings, loans from banks, friends, relatives, or investors)?
    - How much will the expenses be?
4. **Location:** You may want to choose the right place for your bakery.
    - Can choosing a busy area, such as near schools, colleges, or markets, help attract more customers?
    - Can selling online or taking orders through mobile apps help you reach more people?

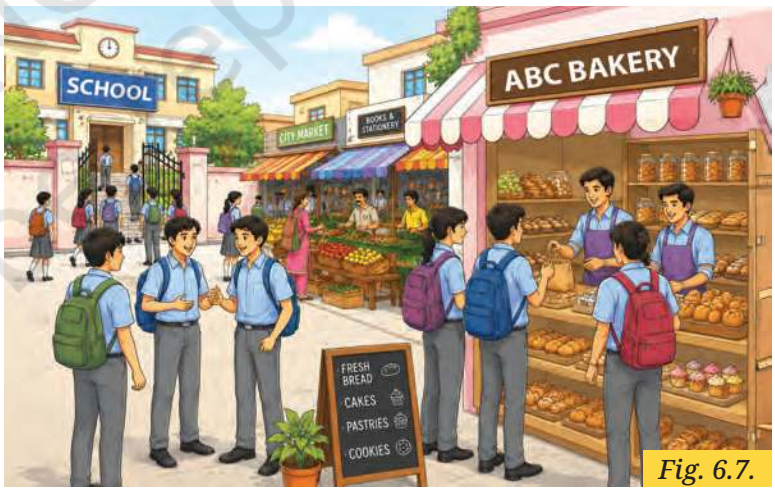


Fig. 6.7.

5. **Human resources (people and skills):** You will have to decide how many people have to be hired and trained, and the required skills for the job.
    - Identify people for roles, such as bakers, helpers, and staff for billing or delivery.

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6. **Pricing and profits:** You may consider fixing prices carefully so that they not only cover your costs and generate profit but also remain affordable for customers.
    - How to balance profitability with affordability when setting prices of goods and services?
    - Can offering a range of pricing options help attract a wider set of customers, for example, cheaper mini cake jars?
7. **Promotion or marketing:** To spread awareness among people about the bakery, you may want to promote it through social media, posters, and provide special offers.
    - What kind of packaging can enhance the appeal and shelf-life of the bakery products?
    - How can customer service be improved to retain customers?



Fig. 6.8.

8. **Challenges and risks:** These are threats that disrupt operations or cause losses, for example, high competition, rising cost of raw materials, changing customer preferences, volatile cash flows, etc. These are an inevitable part of every business venture.
    - How can perishable **inventory** be managed effectively?
    - How can consistent quality in the products be ensured?
    - How should fluctuating customer demand be handled?
    - Are there other bakeries in the locality and how can we compete with them?

Inventory: The goods, materials, and assets a business holds for the purpose of manufacturing, production, or resale.

Accounting: Recording and tracking all the money related to the business so the owner knows how it is performing.

Functional Areas of a Business

The questions in Fig. 6.6 about a business can be grouped into a few main functional areas, like management and operations, finance and **accounting**, human resources, and marketing and sales. Each area has a specific function and helps the business run smoothly. They improve decision making and ensure resources are used properly. Together, they provide structure, better coordination, and help the business grow successfully. Let us learn about them in detail.

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FUNCTIONAL AREAS OF A BUSINESS

Every successful business runs on four key pillars. Together, they turn goals into growth.

1 Management and Operations



Looking after day-to-day matters

Key Focus: Efficient processes and smooth operations

Examples: Production, quality, supply chain, etc.

2 Finance and Accounting



Managing money wisely

Key Focus: Financial health and smart budgeting

Examples: Budgeting, reporting, cash flow, etc.

3 Human Resources



Managing people

Key Focus: Right people and skills

Examples: Hiring new staff, managing employee benefits, and handling workplace conflict resolution, etc.

4 Marketing and Sales



Spreading awareness and driving sales

Key Focus: Customer awareness and business growth

Examples: Advertising, promotions, sales, etc.

Fig. 6.9. Functional areas of a business

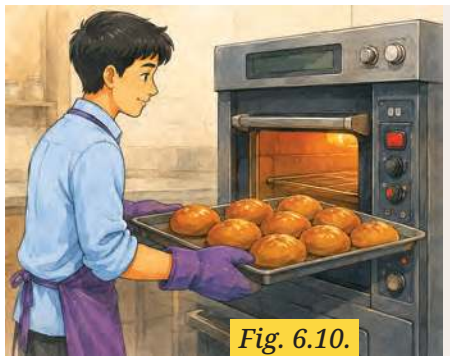
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Fixed cost: Business expenses that remain constant regardless of production volume or sales levels. They do not change with output in the short term and act as indirect or overhead costs, such as rent, salaries, or insurance.

Variable cost: Expenses that change in direct proportion to the volume of goods or services a business produces or sells. They increase as production rises and decrease as production falls, covering raw materials, packaging, etc.

Investment: The allocation of money or resources into an asset, venture, or project with the expectation of generating future income, profit, or value appreciation.

Management and Operations


Fig. 6.10.

Management and operations are essential for running a business smoothly. Management involves planning, organising, and guiding the use of resources to achieve business goals, such as increasing market share through customer satisfaction. Operations focuses on producing and delivering goods or services efficiently and on time. For example, in a bakery, you must choose the right equipment, arrange ingredients, monitor quality, and plan daily production to ensure fresh and high-quality products are made regularly without delay or wastage.

Finance and Accounting

Finance is the management of money in a business. It involves planning, obtaining, and using funds to help the business operate and grow.

For the bakery, you would have to plan for the following:

- Paying **fixed costs:** rent, equipment costs (ovens, mixers, refrigerators), etc.
- Paying **variable costs:** cost of ingredients, salaries, packaging material, etc.
- Investing in growth opportunities
- Managing profits and cash flow

Accounting is the process of recording, organising, and reporting a business's financial transactions. Every entrepreneur needs to understand basic accounting concepts to know how their business is doing. It means keeping track of the money coming in (revenue) and the money going out (expenses), and making sure all records or documents are correct. One important record is the profit and loss account (or income statement). It shows whether the business has made a profit or a loss over a period of time, such as a month or a year. This helps to make informed decisions about spending and **investment**. We can track what the business owns and how much has been borrowed. It also enables compliance with tax laws and regulations of the country.

Profit = Total Revenue – Total Expenses

Revenue is the total money earned by a business from its main operations or sale of goods and services. For example, ABC bakery

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may earn ₹2,95,000 in a month, as seen in its profit and loss account shown in Fig. 6.11.

Expenses include the money spent on running and maintaining a business. These include salaries to employees, electricity bills, cost of raw materials, etc. Further, there may be some interest to be paid on a loan and lastly, taxes to be paid to the government.

PROFIT AND LOSS ACCOUNT
*ABC Bakery (Teen enterprise) | For the month ended March 2026

Income		
	Particulars	**Amount (₹)**
	Revenue from operations (sales)	
	Bread and buns	₹1,20,000
	Pastries and cookies	₹75,000
	Cake orders	₹85,000
	Delivery charges	₹15,000
	Total Income	**₹2,95,000**
Expenses		
	Particulars	**Amount (₹)**
	Cost of goods sold (COGS)	
	Raw materials: flour, sugar	₹1,00,000
	Packaging material	₹12,000
	Rent	₹40,000
	Salaries and wages for staff	₹30,000
	Utilities (electricity and gas)	₹15,000
	Advertising and marketing (social media advertisements, posters)	₹8,000
	Miscellaneous expenses	₹7,000
	Interest on loan	₹10,000
	Total Expenses	**₹2,22,000**
Profit Calculation		
	Particulars	**Amount (₹)**
	Total sales	₹2,95,000
	Total expenses	– ₹2,22,000
	Profit before tax (PBT)	₹73,000
	Tax to be paid	– ₹13,000
	Profit after tax (PAT)	₹60,000

Fig. 6.11. A sample profit and loss account for ABC bakery
**This is a fictional name and any similarity in real world is purely coincidental*

Note: Students need not memorise the above categories.

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Human Resources

People are the heart of every business. Human resources are the individuals employed by the entrepreneur who contribute to the business. For a bakery, functions, such as hiring bakers, helpers, cleaners, and a cashier; training staff in hygiene and baking standards, and ensuring a comfortable and motivating workplace fall under the human resources department. They helps build a strong team with required skills that fosters business growth.

Marketing and Sales

The marketing and sales team helps attract customers and convinces them to buy the products. In a bakery, this includes choosing a catchy name, promoting the business on social media, and offering discounts.

Some simple strategies include:

- Creating unique or seasonal items and customised desserts like mango-flavoured cake.
- Offering discounts, deals, or special offers.
- Providing easy online ordering and delivery.
- Using social media to share photos and videos for awareness among people.
- Promoting eco-friendly practices of recyclable packaging material.

LET'S EXPLORE

→ Interview two people in your vicinity who run a business (tailor, shopkeeper, factory owner, etc.) and find out about their journey of starting the business by asking them the following questions:

- Why did they start the business?
- What were the challenges they faced?
- What were the risks taken?
- What did they learn from the process?

→ Prepare a short report on the tasks an entrepreneur performs at each stage, with reference to Fig. 6.2.

→ Based on the case study of Mohan Singh Oberoi on Page 128, which functional area helped improve the quality of the company's products? How did different functional areas work together to make the business successful? Now that you know about the functional areas of a business, create a business plan for your business idea using the template given on Page 142.



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India's Traditional Entrepreneurial Community

Entrepreneurship in India has deep roots among traditional communities, where skills, occupations, and occupational knowledge have been passed down through generations. Long before modern startups, these communities practised self-employment, innovation, and trade, forming the backbone of India's local economy.

The Chettiar (Nattukottai Chettiar) community from Tamil Nadu is a well-known traditional entrepreneurial community. Historically, Chettiars were traders, bankers, and moneylenders, operating not only across India but also in Sri Lanka, Burma (now Myanmar), Malaysia, and other parts of Southeast Asia. They were known for:

- Strong business ethics and trust-based lending
- Excellent accounting and record-keeping skills
- Reinvesting profits into trade, temples, education, and community welfare

The Chettiar community built wealth through trade in salt, rice, textiles, and finance, often without formal banks. Even today, Chettiar entrepreneurship inspires modern India by showing how risk-taking, discipline, and long-term vision can build sustainable businesses rooted in tradition.



Fig. 6.12. A traditional Chettiar home

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LET'S EXPLORE

Find out more about other regional communities who have excelled as entrepreneurs.



Startups and Their Contribution to the Nation

Startup: A young, early-stage company founded by entrepreneurs offering an innovative product or service.

India's vibrant **startup** ecosystem is built not only on innovation but also on perseverance. All entrepreneurs should be aware that there is a chance of their business ending in failure. So while some startups grow rapidly, others struggle or even close down. As with other things in life, there is nothing wrong with failure if an honest effort has been made. Hence, these experiences contribute to entrepreneurial learning, and every unsuccessful attempt offers lessons that help entrepreneurs develop stronger ideas and build better businesses in the future.

As was famously said by Swami Vivekananda:



> *"Arise, awake and stop not till the goal is reached.*

Atmanirbhar Bharat: A national policy framework launched by the government in 2020 to make the country self-sustaining, boost domestic manufacturing, and reduce import dependency.

With consistent hard work and perseverance, today, India is the third-largest startup ecosystem in the world, powered by its young and talented population. The startup world is growing fast, driven by creativity and technological support, with around 120 unicorns (startups valued at over 1 billion dollars) in 2025. These are working in exciting fields, like e-commerce (online shopping), fin-tech (digital payments), health-tech (online healthcare), and agri-tech (farming technology). Cities like Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Mumbai, and Delhi NCR have become major startup hubs. These ventures are creating jobs, supporting sustainability, and driving economic growth.

Viksit Bharat 2047: The Government of India's vision to transform India into a fully developed nation by 2047, marking 100 years of independence.

In recognition of the importance of promoting entrepreneurship, the government has introduced many schemes, such as Startup India, which supports the vision of **Atmanirbhar Bharat**, focusing on making India self-reliant through innovation and local solutions. As India moves towards the vision of **Viksit Bharat 2047**, entrepreneurship will continue to play a vital role in creating employment, driving innovation, empowering communities, and building a more prosperous, self-reliant, and sustainable nation. The next generation of entrepreneurs may well be sitting in your classroom today, ready to transform ideas into solutions that make a meaningful difference to society.

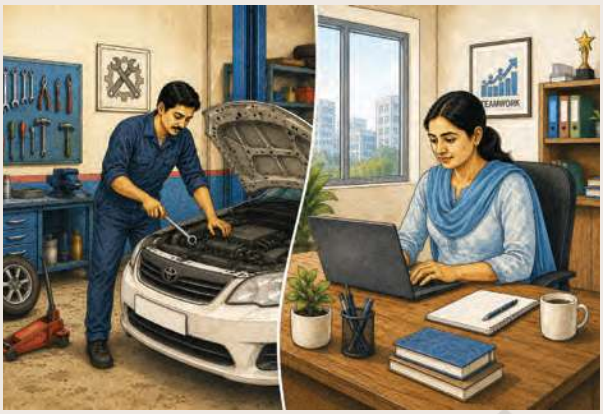
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IMPROVING QUALITY OF LIFE



Medicines, transportation, technology, and innovations

CREATING JOBS AND INCOME



Employment for households

PAYING TAXES TO THE GOVERNMENT



Funding roads, schools, and hospitals

PRODUCING GOODS AND SERVICES



Boosting economic activity

MAKING INNOVATIONS



Driving economic growth and offering solutions

CORPORATE SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY



Education, environment, and healthcare

Fig. 6.13. Contribution of businesses to society and economy

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Before we move on...

- Entrepreneurship is the process of turning ideas into action by identifying opportunities, taking risks, and creating value for society.
- A business plan acts as a roadmap that helps entrepreneurs set goals, organise resources, and make informed decisions.
- Every business has key functional areas—management and operations, finance and accounting, human resources, and marketing and sales—that work together for success.
- Understanding revenue, expenses, profit, and cash flow helps businesses track performance and remain financially sustainable.
- Challenges, risks, and even failures are part of the entrepreneurial journey and provide valuable opportunities for learning and improvement.
- Startups and entrepreneurs drive innovation, create jobs, solve real-world problems, and contribute to the vision of a Viksit Bharat 2047.



Questions and activities

1. Explain why a business can fail even with a great idea if one functional area [finance, human resources (HR), operations, or marketing] is weak. If you were running a bakery, which functional area would you prioritise first and why?
2. Do you think innovation alone is enough to make a business successful? Why or why not?
3. "A business plan is a dynamic roadmap for a startup." Explain this statement with suitable examples. When should one change the business plan?
4. Do you think every entrepreneur should think about the impact of their goods or services on society and the environment? Explain using relevant examples.
5. In 1931, two brothers, Digambar and Govind Dandekar, started a small business in South Mumbai selling ink powder. They began with limited resources, using recycled glass bottles to sell liquid ink. At first, they faced financial problems and struggled to convince customers to trust their products. Instead of giving up,

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they focused on providing good-quality stationery at affordable prices. As the business grew, they noticed that artists in India did not have access to good art materials. Seeing this as an opportunity, they travelled to Glasgow to study colour chemistry and improve their products. After returning to India, they set up a laboratory to develop colours and art supplies suited to Indian needs. Over time, the company expanded into pencils, crayons, geometry boxes, and paints, eventually becoming a well-known brand.

- What entrepreneurial qualities did the Dandekar brothers display?
- What opportunity did they identify in the market?
- Was travelling to Glasgow a risky decision?
- Which functional area helped the company improve its products?
- How did they serve society apart from earning profits?

6. How do you think entrepreneurship is important for India's goal of becoming a developed nation by 2047?
7. Choose a product or service and develop a business plan for it using the following template:
   - Business name
   - Business idea
   - Target customers
   - Product/service and price
   - Marketing idea
   - Basic cost and expected profit
8. Find out about various government schemes to promote entrepreneurs in India. Learn about the eligibility requirements of these schemes. Prepare a write-up and discuss in the class.
9. Take any popular brand and identify:
   - The problem it tackles
   - Its initial target customers
   - How it differentiated itself from other competitors or brands
   - The resources it may have started with

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10. Over the next week, observe your daily routine at school and home. Identify 2–3 problems or inconveniences you or others face. For each problem, answer the following questions in a tabular format:
    - Who faces this problem?
    - How often does it occur?
    - Why hasn't it been solved yet?
    - What business idea could solve it?
    - Would people pay for your solution?
11. Think of your startup idea and fill in the business plan template given below:

    a. Business idea

    Name of the company or shop: _____

    Product/service: _____

    Tagline (optional): _____

    b. Entrepreneur profile

    Founder(s): _____

    Why did you choose this business idea?

    _____

    _____

    What problem does your business solve?

    _____

    _____

    c. Target customers

    Who will buy your product or service?

    ☐ Students ☐ Tourists

    ☐ Parents ☐ Farmers

    ☐ Local residents ☐ Businesses

    ☐ Others: _____

    Describe your target customers:

    _____

    _____

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d. Market research

Find answers to the following questions about potential customers.

Question	Findings
What do the customers need?	
What products or services already exist?	
How is your idea different?	

e. Product or service description

Describe your product or service. List its key features and benefits:

_____

_____

_____

_____

f. Resources required

Resource	What is needed and how much?
Human Resources	
Finance	
Materials	
Technology	
Infrastructure	

g. Operations plan

How will the business work? Write the steps. You may depict this using a flow chart.

h. Marketing plan

How will customers learn about your business?

- ☐ Posters
- ☐ Social media
- ☐ Word of mouth
- ☐ School events
- ☐ Local market
- ☐ Newspapers
- ☐ Other: _____

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i. Financial plan

Source(s) of finance:

Estimated monthly cost on various items:

Item	Cost (₹)
Total Cost	

Details of expected monthly revenue sources:

Source of Income	Amount (₹)
Total Revenue	

Expected Profit:

Revenue – Cost

₹ _____

j. Risks and challenges

What challenges might your business face?

_____

_____

k. Social and environmental impact

How will your business help people or the environment?

_____

_____

l. Conclusion

Why do you believe your business will succeed?

_____

_____

_____

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12. **Visit a factory or a production unit.**

Explore how a business operates by visiting a factory or production unit that manufactures a product. Prepare questions for the owner or manager, such as:

- What product does the factory produce?
- Who are its customers?
- How did the business start?
- What challenges did the business face in its early years?
- How does the business manage its finances?
- How are employees recruited and trained?
- How are products supplied to wholesalers, retailers, or consumers?

During the visit, observe the production process carefully. Note the resources used, such as raw materials, machinery and technology, workers, and managers. Interact with the owner or manager and record key information. Take notes and photographs (if permitted).

After the visit:

- Understand the manufacturing process and create a process map showing the journey of the product from raw materials to the final customer.
- Identify barriers to growth, such as:
  - → **Financial Barriers:** Lack of capital, difficulty obtaining loans or credit, etc.
  - → **Technical Barriers:** Outdated machinery, limited access to technology, etc.
  - → **Human Resource Barriers:** Skill shortages, difficulty hiring or retaining workers, etc.
  - → **Market Barriers:** Competition, limited access to suppliers or customers, etc.
  - → **Regulatory Barriers:** Complex procedures, licences, approvals, or paperwork, etc.

Recommend some practical solutions through which the business could overcome these challenges. Share your findings by preparing

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a presentation and a report highlighting your observations, analysis, and recommendations. The format of the report may be as follows:

- Introduction
- Production or service delivery process (with diagrams or flowcharts)
- Resources required
- Barriers identified (supported by observations or evidence)
- Suggested solutions
- Reflection: key lessons learned from the visit

Notes

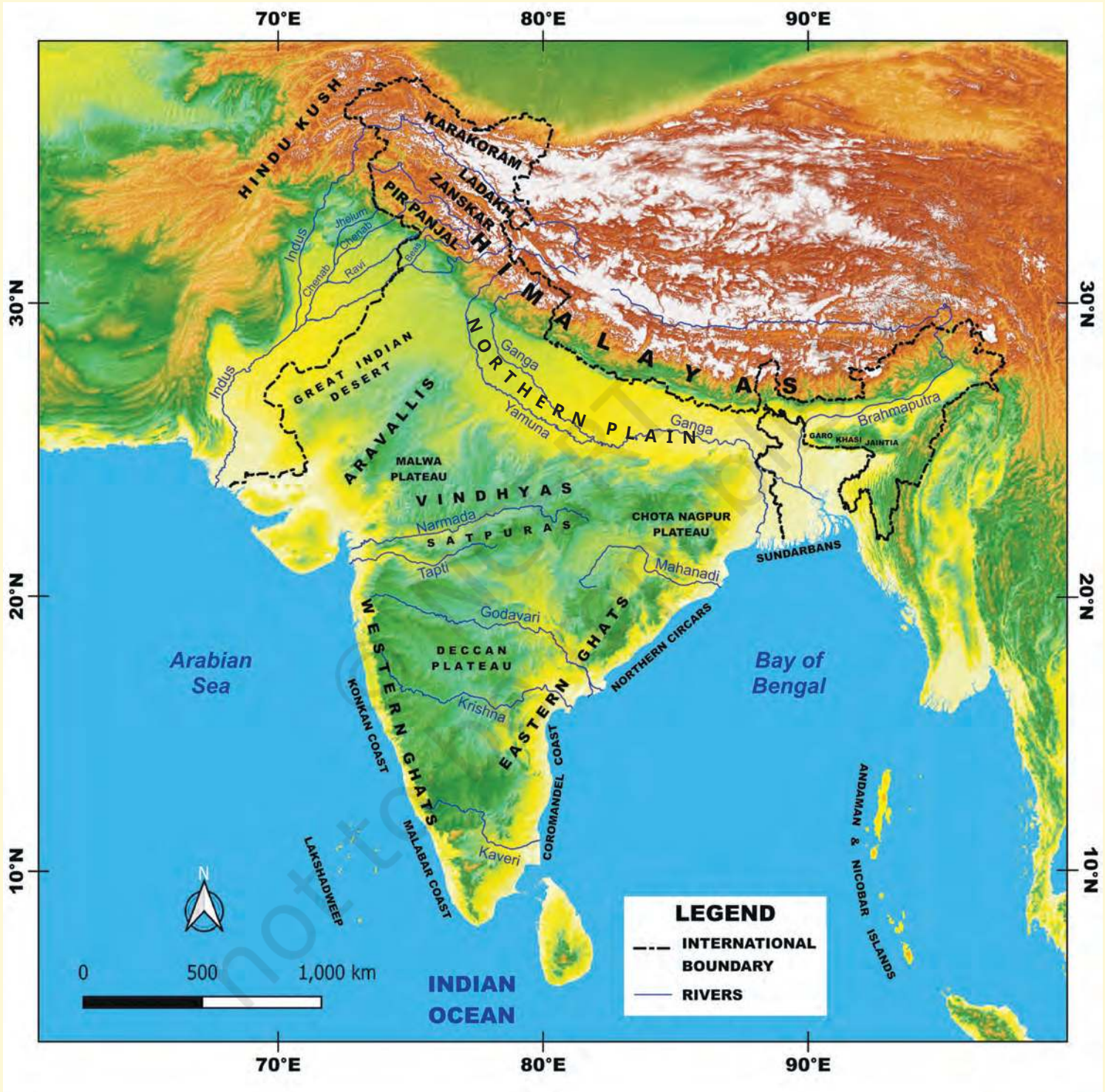
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Political Map of India



Physical Map of India

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1. Organisations and individuals

- Fig. 1.13. https://www.newindianexpress.com/states/tamil-nadu/2017/Dec/26/tamil-nadu-remembers-2004-tsunami-victims-1737199.html
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- Fig. 5.10
- Fig. 6.12

3. AI generated images

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- Fig. 2.1, 2.5
- Fig. 5.1
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